

Chaos Was the Signal.

How Slack grew not by finding the right buyer—
but by arriving at the right moment.

Most teams think outbound is a targeting problem.

"Get the signal. Build the list. Hit send."

The playbook teams swear by:

- Find the "perfect" ICP
- Score leads by firmographics
- Trigger on hiring signals
- Target recent funding rounds
- Blast the right job title

Targeting tells you who. It doesn't tell you when.

X

ICP ≠ Readiness

A perfect-fit company with no pain right now will ignore you — forever.

X

Signals ≠ Intent

Hiring a DevOps engineer isn't intent. It's a data point. Context is everything.

X

Timing beats targeting

The same message to the same person, six months later — completely different result.

Slack entered a market that didn't know it was broken.

2013

Launched as a side project from a failed game studio (Glitch)

The market

Enterprise already had email, Yammer, HipChat, Basecamp

The window

Remote work was accelerating. Tool sprawl was exploding

The insight

The problem wasn't communication — it was coordination collapse

Teams weren't failing at communication. They were drowning in coordination.

The symptoms nobody named:

- 10+ tools, none connected
- New hires took weeks to onboard
- Context scattered across email threads
- Remote teams felt invisible
- "Did you see my message?" became a job
- Projects stalled at handoffs

This wasn't a software problem. It was an organizational nervous system failure.

Not who they are.

What's breaking inside them.

SURFACE SIGNAL

Hired 5 engineers last month

Raised Series A

Uses 6+ productivity tools



Team doubled — no coordination layer exists



Now managing cross-functional chaos at speed



Information is hemorrhaging between silos

REAL SIGNAL

They didn't sell to companies. They infiltrated broken teams.

1

Bottom-up entry

One team member signs up. No sales call. No procurement. No permission.

2

Free tier as Trojan horse

Zero friction to start. Let the chaos do the selling. Product earns the budget conversation.

3

Network effects by design

Every invite pulled another teammate in. The product was the outbound.

4

Chaos was the trigger

Not ICP match. Not intent score. The moment a team hit coordination failure — Slack showed up.

People buy relief, not features.

Pain-first adoption

Users weren't evaluating software. They were escaping chaos. The bar was: anything better than this.

Identity match

"We use Slack" signaled modern, async, remote-ready culture. The tool became a team identity marker.

Virality embedded in workflow

You can't use Slack alone. Every message invited another person. Growth was structurally unavoidable.

\$7.1B

valuation at IPO

(2019)

*Without a single cold call
to land its first 8,000 teams.*

Timing > Targeting.

The best-fit company at the wrong moment = lost deal.

The right moment at any company = your fastest close.

Slack didn't have a better targeting model. It had a better timing model.

Your buyers aren't evaluating you. They're surviving something.

FOR OUTBOUND TEAMS

Stop optimizing your ICP filter. Start identifying internal inflection points — the moment a team's current setup stops working.

FOR PLG COMPANIES

Your product's job is to show up when the pain is acute. Distribution is a timing problem as much as a channel problem.

FOR GTM LEADERS

Intent data is only useful when you can read the internal context behind it. Data $\neq$ signal. Context = signal.

Stop building lists.

Start mapping moments of chaos.

01

Identify your chaos triggers

What internal failure mode does your product solve? Name the exact moment of breakdown.

02

Find the signals of that breakdown

Rapid headcount growth, tool sprawl, leadership change, new GTM motion — what precedes the pain?

03

Build entry at the individual level

Don't pitch the company. Find the one person in pain right now and give them instant relief.

04

Design for spread

The second user should be easier than the first. If your product doesn't pull teammates in — redesign it.

The best GTM motion isn't louder outreach.

It's arriving at the exact moment
your buyer stops being able to cope.